business ends?' Krishna Aiyangar stated that the company had been established 'purely as a business concern on account of the great hardships felt by the merchants of Tuticorin and Ceylon' and that no director had direct political affiliation. Maintaining that 'it was purely a business proposition', he went so far as to state that 'the moment any officer in our company took part in politics, we tried to keep him out of our office. I was the Secretary of that company; and as long as I continued in that office, I had no hand in politics.'[3] This should not be taken at face value. Krishna Aiyangar was being prudent in disavowing politics in his public presentation.



Immediately following the political storm that nearly capsized it, SSNCo first had to meet legal requirements.

As we will recall, SSNCo was registered as a joint-stock company on 16 October 1906. The first general meeting of shareholders had been held on 17 April 1907. As the time between the registration and the date of the meeting was barely six months, not much actual work had been done, and presumably there was little to report.[4] No record of the shareholders' meeting has survived nor have I been able to trace the first annual report, balance sheet and profit and loss account. The next statutory meeting was held in August 1907 and the documents were filed with the registrar of joint stock companies in late 1907.

If the government was meddling in SSNCo's business, the European merchants of Tuticorin too did not keep quiet. BI snitched about the delay in filing annual accounts by its rival. Based on a Madras correspondent's report, the *India* (of London) blamed the BI's local agent of 'carefully discharge[ing] his self-imposed duty of reminding the District Magistrate of the default of the S.S.N.Co. in the matter of publishing the half-yearly balance-sheet of the Company'.[5] The European merchants of Tuticorin had also wired the registrar asking if SSNCo had submitted its half-yearly balance sheet. Though this was none of their business, they urged the